



ALGARVE PORTUGAL

Cataplana in the Algarve

The Moors' conquest of the Iberian peninsula in the 8th century still resonates in Portugal. In the southern coastal province that they named "al-Gharb" – today's Algarve – the new settlers built walled towns and castles, planted rice and citrus trees, and influenced the native cuisine in the shape of the *cataplana*, a cooking utensil still used today to prepare Portugal's finest seafood dishes.



Like the brimming paella pan or clay tagine pot, the sight of a waiter bearing the burnished, domed copper *cataplana* immediately signals the arrival of a dish that's firmly rooted in place – in this case the long, alluring coastline of the Portuguese Algarve. The iconic shape of the *cataplana* – like a hinged, lidded wok – is as recognizable as the golden sands and rocky coves of the region itself, and, as the clasps are released, the steam within rises like wisps of cloud into the azure Algarve skies. It's a fanciful image, but there's a real majesty in both the dish and its presentation that goes far beyond a simple seafood meal.

The word "cataplana" refers to both the cooking vessel and the dish, and to add to the confusion, there is no single dish represented by the name. The most typical – and some would say most authentic – preparation is an *amêijoas na cataplana* (*cataplana* of clams), where clams are steamed in their shells along with chopped onion, tomato, garlic, paprika, a little piri-piri seasoning, and strips of *presunto* (smoked ham) and garlicky *chouriço* sausage. It's a wonderful

combination, with the melded flavors and juices retained during cooking within the sealed *cataplana*. But it's by no means the only *cataplana* dish available, as many restaurants offer versions using other shellfish and fish, particularly *lagosta* (lobster), *gambas* (shrimp), *pescada* (hake), and *tamboril* (monkfish).

Common to all good *cataplanas* are the quality and freshness of the prime ingredients, and that's where the sunny, sea-facing Algarve comes into its own. It's one of Europe's finest resort regions, more relaxed than the heavily developed Spanish costas and featuring an undulating 125-mile (200-km) coastline that's synonymous with both fantastic beaches and terrific seafood. Away from the well-known resorts, on the wilder, far western stretches beyond Lagos or the idyllic eastern sandbank islands between Faro and Tavira, you'll find hidden grottoes, isolated beaches, and charming whitewashed villages that still retain echoes of their Moorish past, and small fishing ports with lively local fish markets that are centuries old but still play a central part in daily life. Rather like the *cataplana* itself, you only need to lift the lid to discover all that's best about the Algarve.



Above The Algarve is dotted with small coves and beaches, such as Praia do Carvalho in Lagoa, which offers sheltered sands and crystal-clear water

What Else to Eat

The classic sight – and smell – of the Portuguese coast is smoke rising off rows of salt-flecked sardines being cooked on an outdoor charcoal grill. Fresh fish, notably **robalo** (sea bass) and **dourada** (bream), get the same treatment, while **atum** (tuna) – a significant Algarve catch – is often baked in an earthenware dish with a caramelized onion sauce (*atum de cebolada*). It's also well worth trying the delicious fish stew called **caldeirada**, but for a thoroughly Portuguese experience, there's no beating **arroz de marisco** served with an Algarve seaside view. This is a spicy, souplike combination of rice and shellfish (clams, certainly, and perhaps also mussels, crab, and shrimp), garnished with cilantro and served with a simple salad.

Three Days on the Algarve

Don't spend all your time on the beach, however tempting. It pays to explore the less-visited inland areas too, particularly the pretty Serra de Monchique (Monchique mountains) in the west and the shores of the Rio Guadiana, the river that forms the border with Spain, in the east.

DAY ONE From Faro airport, head east to the lovely riverside town of **Tavira**, which has a fish market, some fine boutique accommodations, and a line of simple riverside restaurants. Then catch the ferry across to the sandy beaches of the **Ilha de Tavira** (Tavira island).

DAY TWO Make attractive **Albufeira** your next base. Its magnificent cove beaches are within easy reach of town. Take a side trip by car up to the old hillside village of **Alte** for lunch, and return via the medieval walled town of **Silves**.

DAY THREE Visit the western headland of **Sagres**, with its historic fort and dramatic beaches. North of here along the western, Atlantic coast, as far as **Odeceixe**, lies a series of remote beaches and youth-oriented surf resorts, backed by the mountains of the **Serra de Monchique**.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Faro **international airport** is used by many holiday operators and budget airlines. A **car** is the best way to get around, though there is a useful **train** service between Lagos in the west and Vila Real de Santo António in the east.

WHERE TO STAY

Hotel Lagosmar (inexpensive) is a traditional, family-run guesthouse in the centre of the busy resort of Lagos. www.lagosmar.com
Pousada de Sagres (moderate) is a quiet retreat in the far western Algarve. www.pousadas.pt
Casa Três Palmeiras (expensive) is a wonderfully sited cliff-top villa above the beach near Praia da Rocha. www.casatrespalmeiras.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

www.visitalgarve.pt